Fire & Life Safety SOP: Alarm Response and Evacuation

Standard operating procedure for corporate campuses and multi-tenant towers

Purpose: to make sure every person on site knows what to do in the first ten minutes of a fire alarm, and that the control room, wardens and security act in the same order every time. Scope: all occupied buildings, basements and car parks. Owner: Head of Facilities. Review: every six months and after every drill or incident.

1. Roles

Role	Primary duty	Back-up
Fire control room operator	Verify the alarm, call the fire service, run the announcement script	Security supervisor
Floor warden	Sweep the floor, close doors, direct people to stairs, report headcount	Deputy warden
Security supervisor	Open emergency exits, hold lifts at ground, meet the fire service at the gate	Site manager
Engineer on shift	Confirm panel status, isolate affected AHUs, check pump health	Duty engineer
Site manager	Incident commander until the fire service takes over	Head of Facilities

2. Alarm response (first ten minutes)

1. Alarm sounds: the control room operator identifies the zone and device on the panel and silences nothing until the floor is verified.
2. Within 60 seconds a warden or security guard visits the zone. A confirmed fire, smoke or burning smell triggers evacuation.
3. The operator calls the fire service on 101 and the site manager, and starts the staged evacuation announcement.
4. Wardens sweep their floor, check toilets, meeting rooms and phone booths, then use the stairs. Lifts are not used.
5. Engineers shut down the AHUs serving the affected zone, start the pressurisation fans and confirm the pumps are on auto.
6. At the assembly point wardens report headcount to the site manager using the visitor and attendance lists.
7. The site manager hands over to the fire officer, shares the floor plans and the hazard list, and keeps the gate clear.

3. Evacuation announcement script

"May I have your attention please. A fire alarm has been activated in the building. Please leave by the nearest staircase and walk to the assembly point. Do not use the lifts. Do not stop to collect belongings. Wardens will guide you." Repeat every 30 seconds in English and the local language until the all-clear.

4. People who need help

- Maintain a confidential register of people who cannot use stairs unaided; wardens know their floor locations
- Use refuge areas and evacuation chairs; tell the fire service where each person waits
- Visitors are the host's responsibility until the host reports them at the assembly point

5. After the incident

- Do not re-enter until the fire officer permits it; reset the panel only with the fire engineer present
- Log the event within 24 hours: time of alarm, cause, response times, injuries, damage and lessons
- Run a debrief within five working days and update this SOP where the response fell short
- Test every evacuated device and replace anything operated or damaged before the building is declared safe

6. Drills

Run an unannounced evacuation drill at least twice a year per building, one in office hours and one at shift change. Record the time to clear each floor; the target is under four minutes per ten floors. Wardens who miss a drill are re-trained within a month.